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However, earlier SF contains numerous examples of corporations that become de facto rulers of the world, such as the Presteign clan in Alfred Bester's *The Stars My Destination* (1956) or General Technics in John Brunner's *Stand on Zanzibar* (1968), not to mention the monolithic multinationals found throughout Philip K. Dick's novels.

From Lauren Beukes's *Moxyland* to Max Barry's *Jennifer Government*, numerous contemporary SF novels examine the conflicts that arise from technologies underpinning both systems of social credit and social control. Although these themes can overlap, alien invasion stories typically focus on conflict between humans and aliens, while first-contact stories, which take a more anthropological view of encounters between humans and extraterrestrial civilizations, tend to focus on diplomatic relations.

²These narratives rise and fall in popularity and, to some extent, reflect the anxieties of the era in which they were written: Edgar Rice Burroughs's 1925 novel, *The Moon Men*, was influenced by the Red Scare of the post-World War I period, and the Cold War would produce a number of alien invasion narratives involving covert infiltration of the human body and mind-control, notably Robert Heinlein's 1951 novel *The Puppet Masters*.

One of the earliest examples of this theme can be found in Murray Leinster's short novel *First Contact* (1945), which is among the first to describe a universal translation device (a perennial interest of SF creators and fans, not to mention technology companies).

Although Asimov introduced the ever-popular theme of robot uprisings to SF, Russian-American SF author Isaac Asimov made equally important contributions to AI-themed SF through his short story collection *I, Robot*. Such stories explore what it means to be human on both a personal level (What is gender?

However, for every chilling rise of the machines tale, such as Daniel Wilson's *Robopocalypse* or Todd McAulty's *The Robots of Gotham*, there are thought-provoking novels featuring sympathetic synthetic lifeforms navigating an unsympathetic world, such as Becky Chambers's *A Close and Common Orbit* or Martha Wells's *All Systems Red*. By contrast, stories about computer-like humans focus on human evolution

as opposed to human obsolescence.

Charles Stross's 2005 novel *Accelerando* traces the shift from human to posthuman by following three successive generations of the same family before, during, and after the Singularity, while Greg Egan's *Diaspora* shows a trifurcated thirtieth-century posthuman humanity comprised of fleshers (i.e., normal humans), Gleisner robots (human brains embodied in machines), and polises (supercomputers containing digital copies of billions of humans).

Although there is no shortage of depictions of societies transformed by cybernetic technology, many SF stories about computer-like humans focus on individual cyborgs, or augmented humans whose capabilities are enhanced or extended by technology.

Similarly, the plot of Anne McCaffrey's 1969 novel *The Ship Who Sang* centers around humans with severe birth defects whose disembodied brains are harnessed to power starships.

However, as advances in technology transform science fiction into science fact, the focus of these stories shifts towards achievements still beyond our grasp: namely, immortality.

Although this novel is not the first to explore mind uploads as a means of cheating death, it does introduce a notable feature of technological immortality in SF, namely, that it depends on one's resources: wealthy individuals can pay to extend their lifespan indefinitely, while others cannot.

In biopunk novels such as Paul J. McAuley's *Fairyland* (1995), Paolo Bacigalupi's *The Windup Girl* (2008), and Jeff VanderMeer's *Borne* (2017), biotechnology even contributes to the creation of sentient beings that lack the rights and protections afforded to humans.

Accompanying this trend is a rise in dystopian fiction in which current problems lead to unrest and societal breakdown, or even human extinction. Published in 1962, J.G. Ballard's *The Drowned World* (and its companion novel, *The Drought*) offers one of the earliest realistic fictional explorations of a world ravaged by climate change.

Although it explicitly cites the greenhouse effect and the melting of the polar ice caps as catalysts for widespread environmental devastation, the novel attributes the destruction to natural disaster rather than human activity.

A clear forerunner of climate fiction is the *dying Earth* novel, which takes its name from Jack Vance's 1950 short story collection *The Dying Earth* about a far-future world in which the sun has reached the end of its lifespan. Blending SF and fantasy, Vance's book spawned an entire subgenre, reaching its apotheosis with the

publication of Gene Wolfe's science fantasy epic series *Book of the New Sun*. Unlike the swift catastrophes of most apocalyptic and post-apocalyptic fiction, where a single asteroid or nuclear bomb ends human civilization in a flash, dying Earth stories resemble the slow-pocalypses of climate fiction, in which a dwindling human population survives in the ruins of civilization. Tone is arguably more important than setting: the lyrical, elegiac tone that permeates dying earth novels can be seen in nonclimate apocalyptic fiction such as Emily St. John Mandel's *Station Eleven*. Novels that take a dying Earth approach to climate change include Margaret Atwood's *MaddAddam* trilogy (beginning with *Oryx and Crake*), Claire Vaye Watkins's *One*. One notable difference is that in the dying Earth subgenre, survivors are more likely to respond to their situation with resignation, whereas in modern climate fiction the emphasis is on surviving, adapting, and (where possible) rebuilding.

Recently, the adage history is written by the victors seems apropos as change wars make their way back into SF for the first time in decades.

Annalee Newitz's *The Future of Another Timeline* casts human history as a kind of Wikipedia page that can be edited by time travelers and pits a coalition of feminist activists against a regressive group of male chauvinists in an ongoing campaign to reshape societal rules and norms.

For every SF novel that contemplates humanity's probable extinction, another looks beyond the bounds of Earth to imagine humanity's future among the stars.

Hopeful SF has a long and storied history.

James White's *Sector General* novels (1962-99), about a hospital space station staffed by medical personnel both human and alien, offers uplifting accounts of interspecies cooperation; its diverse (at least, on the alien side; humans are mostly male and entirely white) cast works together to save lives, not destroy them.

Nevertheless, the project of creating an inclusive body of SF continues, with recent anthologies such as *A People's Future of the United States*, edited by Victor LaValle and John Joseph Adams, and *Octavia's Brood: Science Fiction from Social Justice Movements*, edited by Walidah Imarisha and adrienne marie brown) collecting SF stories from diverse groups of contributors that approach speculative fiction as a form of activism.

The rules, first laid out in Asimov's 1942 short story *Runaround*, are as follows: First Law: A robot may not injure a human being or, through inaction, allow a human being to come to harm.